

Brazilian Artist's Mural Shows Climate Disasters

Brazilian artist and activist Mundano recently used some unusual substances to paint a picture on a building in Sao Paulo. The paint included materials, such as ash and mud, collected from natural disasters.

Mundano created the mural to highlight the issue of climate change. Extreme weather events have been causing destruction across Brazil.

The mural is very large – over 30 meters high and 48 meters wide. The artist used ash from wildfires and mud from floods. His painting shows the gray remains of trees on a brown land so dry it is cracked. The picture represents the deforestation and severe drought in the Amazon rainforest.

The mural also shows Indigenous activist Alessandra Korap wearing a circle of flowers around her head. She holds a sign that says: “Stop the destruction #keepyourpromise.” The artist says those messages are directed to Cargill, a massive soybean producer based in the United States.

FILE - Sky view of floods in Eldorado do Sul, Rio Grande do Sul state, Brazil, taken on May 9, 2024. It has been called the worst natural disaster to hit the area. (Photo by Nelson ALMEIDA / AFP)

Soy farming is one of the biggest causes of deforestation in the Amazon.

Cargill says on its website that it will eliminate deforestation from its supply chain in Brazil, Argentina, and Uruguay by 2025.

Mundano is seeking to hold the company accountable.

“We are tired of being a country, a continent where we and the natural resources we have here are exploited. ... We have to regenerate our planet instead of destroying it,” the artist said in an interview.

Cargill did not immediately answer a request for comment.

Over the past few months, human-caused wildfires have severely damaged protected places in the Amazon area. The fires burned in parts of both the large Cerrado savanna and the world's largest tropical wetland, the Pantanal.

Smoke spread over a very large area and affected the air quality in some Brazilian cities.

Drought has caused a critical situation nationwide. Weather predictions show that this will continue in much of the country through at least the rest of October. This information comes

from Cemaden, Brazil's disaster warning center.

Droughts & floods

On October 22, the depth of the Amazon's Negro River measured 12.46 meters, representing a small increase from 10 days earlier. At that time, the river was at its lowest point since measurements started 122 years ago.

And this last reported measure is still about 6 meters below normal for the same date in earlier years.

Rivers in Brazil's Amazon always rise and fall with its rainy and dry seasons. But the dry season this year has been much worse than usual.

Earlier this year, a severe flood in the southern state of Rio Grande do Sul killed more than 180 people, affected over 2 million people, and destroyed city communities.

Sky view of floods in Eldorado do Sul, Rio Grande do Sul state, Brazil, taken on May 9, 2024. It has been called the worst natural disaster to hit the area. (Photo by Nelson ALMEIDA / AFP)

Mundano, who calls himself an "artist" (a combination of "artist and activist"), used mud from that flood to create the new mural. The activist group Movement of People Affected by Dams collected the materials.

Mundano also used ashes from Brazil's fires in the Atlantic Forest, the Pantanal, and the Cerrado. He also used earth found in waste containers in Sao Paulo and clay collected from the Sawre Muybu Indigenous land in the Amazon, where Alessandra Korap is from.

"From floods to droughts, everything is connected!" Mundano said recently in an Instagram post. He included a video showing the mural in Sao Paulo. The artist said it is his biggest mural ever.

Three years ago, he used ash from the Amazon to create a similar mural in Sao Paulo. That work showed a firefighter standing in deforested areas. It also showed a cow farm and trucks loaded with cut trees.

I'm Anna Matteo.

Eléonore Hughes And Felipe Campos Mello reported this story for the Associated Press. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

cracked - adj. แตก, ร้าว (เช่น จากการถูกระแทกแรงๆ จนพื้นผิวเกิดรอยแยก)

drought - n. ความแห้งแล้ง, ช่วงเวลาที่อากาศแห้งแล้งยาวนาน

eliminate - v. กำจัด, ขจัด, ทำให้หมดไป

supply chain - n. ห่วงโซ่อุปทาน (ลำดับของกระบวนการ ธุรกิจ และอื่นๆ ที่เกี่ยวข้องกับการผลิตและจัดจำหน่ายสินค้า)

accountable - adj. ต้องรับผิดชอบ, มีความรับผิดชอบ (ในการชี้แจงการกระทำ)

exploit - v. เอาเปรียบ, ใช้ประโยชน์โดยไม่เป็นธรรมเพื่อผลประโยชน์ของตนเอง

savanna - n. ทุ่งหญ้าสะวันนา (ทุ่งหญ้าเขตร้อนหรือกึ่งเขตร้อนที่มีต้นไม้กระจายอยู่ทั่วไป)

tropical - adj. เขตร้อน (เกี่ยวกับ หรือมีลักษณะของภูมิอากาศหรือภูมิอากาศที่ไม่มีน้ำค้างแข็งและมีอุณหภูมิสูงพอที่จะรองรับการเจริญเติบโตของพืชได้ตลอดทั้งปี หากมีความชื้นเพียงพอ)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What unusual substances did Mundano use for his painting on a building in Sao Paulo?

- A. Oil paints and traditional pigments
- B. Ash and mud collected from natural disasters
- C. Chemical dyes and synthetic materials
- D. Watercolors and plant-based extracts

2. What was Mundano's primary purpose for creating the mural?

- A. To promote local tourism in Sao Paulo
- B. To beautify an old building with new artwork
- C. To highlight the issue of climate change and its impacts
- D. To demonstrate new artistic techniques with natural materials

3. Which of the following best describes the visual content of Mundano's mural, according to Paragraph 4?

- A. A thriving jungle full of diverse animal life
- B. A cityscape with towering skyscrapers and modern infrastructure
- C. Gray remains of trees on dry, cracked brown land
- D. Portraits of famous environmental scientists

4. What specific environmental issues in the Amazon rainforest are represented by the imagery in the mural?

- A. Soil erosion and air pollution
- B. Deforestation and severe drought
- C. Overfishing and water contamination
- D. Urban expansion and industrial waste

5. Who is the Indigenous activist depicted in the mural holding a sign?

- A. Anna Matteo
- B. Mundano
- C. Alessandra Korap
- D. Nelson ALMEIDA

6. The message “Stop the destruction #keepyourpromise” on the sign in the mural is directed towards which entity?

- A. The Brazilian government
- B. Local communities in Sao Paulo
- C. Cargill, a massive soybean producer
- D. International aid organizations

7. What is identified as one of the biggest causes of deforestation in the Amazon?

- A. Logging for timber production
- B. Road construction
- C. Soy farming
- D. Cattle ranching

8. What commitment has Cargill made on its website regarding deforestation?

- A. To cease all operations in Brazil, Argentina, and Uruguay by 2025
- B. To eliminate deforestation from its supply chain in Brazil, Argentina, and Uruguay by 2025
- C. To increase its deforestation activities to meet global demand
- D. To plant new trees to compensate for past deforestation by 2030

9. What does Mundano seek to do regarding Cargill's actions?

- A. To collaborate with them on sustainable farming initiatives
- B. To commend them for their stated commitments
- C. To hold the company accountable for its impact
- D. To negotiate a partnership for future art projects

10. Based on Mundano's quote in Paragraph 10, what is his sentiment regarding the exploitation of natural resources?

- A. He believes they are being managed responsibly.
- B. He expresses satisfaction with current resource utilization.
- C. He feels they are being exploited unfairly and calls for regeneration.
- D. He suggests that exploitation is a necessary part of economic growth.

11. Which natural areas in Brazil have recently been severely damaged by human-caused wildfires?

- A. Only the Amazon rainforest
- B. The Cerrado savanna and the Pantanal wetland
- C. Coastal mangroves and coral reefs
- D. Urban parks and agricultural lands

12. According to Cemaden, what is the current severe weather condition affecting Brazil, and how long is it predicted to last?

- A. Severe floods, expected to worsen until December
- B. A critical drought, predicted to continue through at least the rest of October
- C. Intense heatwaves, forecast to ease by mid-November
- D. Unseasonal heavy rains, anticipated to last for several months

13. What significant historical low point did the Amazon's Negro River reach in October?

- A. Its highest recorded level in 50 years
- B. Its lowest point since measurements started 122 years ago
- C. A stable level that has not changed in decades
- D. A level slightly above its historical average

14. What other severe natural disaster, apart from drought, impacted the southern state of Rio Grande do Sul earlier this year?

- A. A major earthquake
- B. A series of volcanic eruptions
- C. A severe flood
- D. A powerful hurricane

15. From which specific event did Mundano collect the mud to create his new mural?

- A. The recent mudslides in the Amazon rainforest
- B. The severe flood in the southern state of Rio Grande do Sul
- C. The ongoing drought in the Cerrado savanna
- D. The aftermath of a wildfire in the Pantanal